

פִּינָחָס בֶּן אֶלְעָזָר בֶּן אֶהֱרֹן הִכָּהֵן הָשִׁיב אֶת חֲמָתִי מֵעַל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּקִנְיָאֻם אֶת קִנְיָאֹתֵי בְּתוּכֶם וְלֹא כָלִיתִי אֶת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּקִנְיָאֹתֵי: לָכֵן אָמַר ה' הִנְנִי נֹתֵן לְךָ אֶת בְּרִיתִי שְׁלוֹם. The word שְׁלוֹם has an interesting letter, one of the very rare letters in the Torah which has a special aspect. The vav is called a קְטִיעָא. It's a vav with a split in it. Normally, any letter in the Torah with a split in it is פָּסוּל, but this letter is written בדווקא with a split in it. There are many מדרשים on this incredibly unusual occurrence. The sefer בְּתוּנוֹת עוֹר brings a תוספות in זבחים that says that because of פנחס's ברית שלום with הקדוש ברוך הוא, he was able to be 380 כהנים גדולים from his descendants.

Now, as we well know, in בית ראשון there were fewer כהנים גדולים than in בית שני. בית שני had only 80 and בית שני had 300. נבך, in בית שני there was a lowering of the מדרגה, they died every year on כיפור because they didn't make it through the עבודה, but they still wanted to be גדול, not because of their seeking prestige. The תשוקה, the zeal to attain קדושה, prompted them to take this job, even though they knew the consequences could be devastating.

Now what's interesting, the sefer בְּתוּנוֹת עוֹר brings, is if you take away the bottom of the קְטִיעָא, it makes it from ש ל י ם into ש ל י ם. If you add up the גמטריא for ש ל י ם, it's 380. So we see that the very letter that symbolizes peace also alludes to the 380 כהנים גדולים who came from פנחס.

In view of this particular ברית שלום, I want to bring down a vort from Rav Komornick's sefer A Short Vort: from where do we learn out all of the הלכות of making a קנין? We know when people get married, there's a קנין, הרי את מקודשת לי, and the חתן has to give the כלה something to make the קנין. Where do all of the הלכות of getting married, of making a קנין of marriage, come from? Remarkably, from the purchase that אברהם made when buying the עפרון as a burial site for אמו. We're talking about a wedding, and we learn it from the opposite, a קבורה.

He brings down a beautiful idea tying these two events together. The Torah tells us that עפרון was willing to give the field away to אברהם for free. But when אברהם insisted on paying, עפרון responded: אֲרָבַע מֵאוֹת בָּבָא מְצִיעָא that, adjusted properly, this comes out to four million dollars. עפרון thought he made the sale of the century, a tiny piece of land for an enormous amount of money. He definitely thought he got the better deal. But turning around, what did אברהם think about the deal? He wouldn't have been disappointed at all. He would have said, "Only 400 דינרים for a heritage, for a מסורה, for all of ישראל, כלל, for נצחיות in המכפלה? What a deal!"

What do we see from this? Both parties walked away saying, "I got the better deal." And that's the message for a חתונה. The חתן and כלה know their faults and shortcomings, and yet each one says, "They're willing to marry me? I can't believe it. I got the better deal."

So here we're talking about פנחס getting a deal from Hashem ברית שלום. Look at what he got. He received the כהונה and all the כהנים גדולים from his lineage. To make a ברית with הקדוש ברוך הוא - which every one of us does, whether man, woman, or child, whether בפועל or ברוחניות - is the best deal we could possibly make. To make a deal with Hashem is the best investment we can ever have.

